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Red Holloway

Red Holloway can be found in diverse musical settings around the world. His alto and tenor saxophone sounds are heard on classic jazz recordings with Warren Vache and traditional blues with John Mayall. Red has performed frequently with Joe Williams and organist Jack McDuff. Currently Red makes his home on the West Coast. He is often seen at jazz festivals and parties across the country where he is appreciated for his sense of humor as well as his outstanding musical skills.

Red was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on March 4, 1995 by Monk Rowe and Dr. Michael Woods.

MW: We are here filming some very important interviews with jazz musicians for an archive to be held at Hamilton College. And it's our great privilege to have Red Holloway with us. My name is Dr. Michael Woods and my associate is Monk Rowe. Monk, would you like to start things here?

MR: Well first of all it's a great pleasure to be here. We've had some interesting conversations with some other fine musicians, and Red Holloway has been on our list, and we're glad to have him here as an alto and tenor saxophonist. And we wondered, one thing we are interested in is how jazz has changed over the years for you — what made you want to get into music as a kid, and just some things about your own career that you could share with us.

RH: Well, see I'll be 68 years old this year. And when I was a kid, you could either be a Pullman porter, you could become a barber, if your folks had money you might be able to become a doctor. But if you had no talents and you were nice looking, you could become a pimp. But basically most people became, most men became Pullman porters. So I had none of those qualifications, and since my mother was a pianist and my father played violin, I decided maybe I should try to be a musician. But I always liked boxing because, you know like Sugar Ray and Joe Louis they were my idols, you know? And a friend of mine and I, we went to school together, named Johnny Bratton. We used to be in the gym together all the time, we used to run five miles a day for ten years. I started at about 8 or 9 years old, and he became — well we were amateur boxers. And he became a champion boxer, I don't know if you're familiar with Johnny Bratton, but he won one of those titles from Kid Gavilan from Cuba back in the 50s, but anyway, we were close friends. And I used to do this for a while, but I always liked music. But after about 37 amateur fights and getting my head smashed in, I really decided I should be a musician. And there were no, see in those days there were some real bad days back in the latter 30s and early 40s,

like, well you made $2.50 an hour as a musician. And when you were making $6.00 a night and all you could eat and drink, that was good money. So basically that's when I decided I really wanted to be a musician. And even though the money wasn't an awful lot, you know, there wasn't a requirement, the cost of living was down, so you didn't have to pay a lot of money. You could rent a house for like $20 a month, stuff like that. And it was very cheap. Of course you didn't make a lot of money but it didn't cost a lot of money. In fact, my first job that I ever had – period -- was as a busboy for $9.98 — well actually it was $10.00, they took out two cents for Social Security — $9.98 a week, seven days a week, 7 'til 7. So I'm just saying this was back in the 40s, you know? So this is why I decided to be a musician, and so far I've managed to keep doing this. And I was raised in Chicago. I was born in Helena, Arkansas. But you know, in Chicago, this is where everybody from the south and everywhere, they would come to Chicago first and eventually they would move on to New York. And when I first really started making some what I call "serious money" I was working with Eugene Wright, I don't know if you're familiar with him, he was a bass player.

MR: He played with Brubeck later, didn't he?

RH: Yeah. Senator Eugene Wright. I was in high school and he called me to work with his band. In fact I worked with his band until I went to the service. So like there were a lot of different reasons why I wanted to play music.

MW: Did you have a hero? Did you have somebody on your particular instrument that you liked their sound?

RH: Oh, yeah, Lester Young, you know. Really the first thing I started was with a clarinet because Benny Goodman and Lionel Hampton and they were working with Benny Goodman and I wanted to play clarinet which I did for a while in school, but when I heard Lester Young and the Whirleys, man, I don't want no parts on the clarinet. I wanted to play saxophone. So basically that's when I went — There was a school teacher, a music teacher just out of high school called Captain Walter Dyett and like Johnny Griffin went, well we were in the same band together at the time, when he graduated in '45 and went with Hamp. And then there was Benny Green the trombone player and even Gene Ammons took a few courses from him. So he was a very, very important person in my life and a lot of other musicians' lives. So that's basically how I started really playing music for a living.

MR: Was being in Chicago at that time, it was a big blues town, right?

RH: Oh, yeah.

MR: Did you feel that influence in playing?

RH: And how, let me tell you. I don't know if you're familiar, well I'm sure you're probably

the Big Three Trio because all three of them weighed about 300 pounds or more apiece. And I knew him very well. In fact when he went with Cobra Records myself and Hal Ashby was his favorite saxophone players. In fact I just picked up a re-issue of the Cobra label things that was done during that era during the 50s of Cobra Records. And I got a lot of CDs that Hal Ashby and myself were on with Willie Dixon. And of course Willie Dixon used to write a lot of stuff for Muddy Waters and Koko Taylor. And I played with all the blues players. In fact, Sunnyland Slim, Memphis Slim, in fact I just finished an album last year with Etta James called "Mistra Lady." She just got a Grammy for it a few days ago. So I've been playing — and Ruth Brown — I played with Ruth Brown. She got her first Grammy. I played with Joe Williams — he got his first Grammy, in fact I was the band leader on that session. He got his first Grammy. So I mean I've been working with a lot of blues players, you know? And I feel if you don't know how to play the blues, you really don't know too much about music. Technique don't mean nothing if you don't have no feeling. You know, if you ain't got no soul, forget about it.

MW: In other words, it don't mean a thing —

RH: If it ain't got that swing. You know. And I don't say every song has to be soulful, but it should have a feeling. Music is supposed to be something that's beautiful and something that people can feel. And when it loses its feeling and beauty, that was one of the things that really kind of inspired me from Coleman Hawkins and Lester Young because of the fact that they just had so much feeling. And then when I heard Ben Webster, I said, "Oh, sure." You know like this dude was just like a big gorilla, but when he picked up that saxophone, he was just like — some women used to call him their "prince." But he was, you know it's funny how they always say, which is true, you can't judge a book by its cover because like you look at a person and you say, "Man this sucker here, what the hell can he play? I mean he look like he could be pouring iron." You know, and then when they start to playing or something —. I'll give you a good example, like Oscar Peterson, he's such a big man, you would say, "What kind of music could he play?" But when he sits down at the piano, you say, "Wow." You can tell that there's been a lot of study going on there and there has been a lot of thinking, you know? And see now today, when I was growing up you couldn't, there were no jazz studies. I went to the Chicago Conservatory, but everything was classical. But now they got schools where you can go and learn to play jazz. Now I don't mean that you necessarily can be a great jazz player, but you will know all of the necessary things that you should know.

MW: You can become proficient.

RH: Yeah, and so the thing is, it's something that you have to feel. And I was around more blues players. In fact, my mother and Roosevelt Sykes went to school together. And my

with him. So now when you're playing the blues every night, you got to, you can't help but know the blues, and feel the blues. So that was one of the, that's really how I got started, and that's—

MR: That's still part of your playing today.

RH: Oh, yeah. I still love the blues.

MR: Can you describe what a typical recording session might have been like for one of the blues artists? Because today we're familiar with how bands sometimes spend weeks and months making records, and they make them in sections, and they overdub—

MW: And they do the rhythm section first, they do the solo tracks after that, and all this intricate mixing.

RH: That is so ridiculous. That is just really stupid. And I don't care who hears it that's stupid. That's just a waste of time and money. The way we used to do, and the way I still do myself, is what I'll do is like when I was working with Brother Jack McDuff, even John Mayall, now he's a British, father of the British blues, I worked with him. We would rehearse the stuff at his house, all the changes that had to be made, then we would play it on some jobs. We'd play it maybe for a month. And I still do that, and McDuff. We'll play our stuff for maybe 2-3 months and there would be, in fact, when I worked and made the first record for McDuff, him and George Benson and Joe Dukes had been playing together for oh a couple of years. And I had joined him like his saxophone player had to go down south because somebody had died in the family. And I joined his band, like at 3:00 that day and we rehearsed from 3 until about 6 the stuff that he was going to do. And we went to the studio and they had an audience and the audience had been drinking from 6 until 8, that's when the session was starting. And basically everyone knew the music except myself, you know, but I went and rehearsed with him that day and I wrote down what I was playing, more or less the melodic lines, so it made it rather easy. Whereas George and McDuff was playing the harmony. So when we went to the session that night, it was perfect. The people, they had been, they got high and they had been drinking and eating barbecue ribs and just having a good time. So they were high and loose, and that was the album "Live at the Front Room." And when it came out it was a hit. And that's really what started the whole thing off. So like, even when I worked with John Mayall, we would practice the stuff and we'd play it on gigs, then we'd go in the studio and they'd take maybe 5 hours to do an album. But I mean this is stupid, going in, well they don't, one of the thing is they don't have anything prepared. That's usually what it is. Most of the groups of today that tie up a studio for two and three months, cost $150,000-$200,000. That is stupid. And because usually most of them don't really know anything about the instruments. In fact there was a girl's group and they had this hit, and

next thing that you're going to do. You've got this big hit" whatever the name of it was. And so they say, "Well, we're going to go in and try and learn how to play these instruments." And I mean this was on television, and I said well I'll be darned.

MR: Things change.

RH: Well you know my daughter, she says like people are getting so accustomed to just mediocre stuff, they don't know good shit when they hear it.

MW: I was going to come with something behind that and ask you, you know, a jazz musician sometimes people challenge jazz musicians to think that oh they're just somehow winging stuff off the top of the head, and I tell them I said, "Anybody that can play two 32-bar choruses or 64-bars with wonderful burning ideas is a theoretician." Am I right? You can't play this music and play it well with all the lines where they're supposed to be and the motivic development and the terms and articulations without being a theoretician.

RH: Yes sir you're right. You have got to sit and figure it out. Now some people have a great knack for that. Some people are just what you call naturals. I mean you know they have, well, Errol Garner is a good one, you know, he didn't really have the training but he set down at that piano enough and studied and taught himself enough that he knew what to, what to put where and when, so that's why I say you've got some people that are just naturally musically inclined, and they are able to do certain things like that. Then you got some, I had a cousin, because I was taking piano lessons, he went and took piano lessons for five years, and today he can't play anything. In fact, he could only play what he read, and now he can't do that. So I'm just saying, some people do not have that particular type, that knack that you need, that certain talent that you need to do certain things. And then you have some that really don't, well Benny Green. Benny Green, he would only study when he had to. Great trombone player. He may not play for 4-5 months; pick up his trombone like he just played it an hour ago. You know some people are just like that. Gene Ammons, he's another one, but Gene studied. But one of the things, I mean he had just — his sound was really one of the great things about his playing, as well as his articulation and stuff. Nevertheless his sound was really, that's one of the things I was taught, says, one of the things you get first for identification is a sound. Your own sound. Now if you're going to copy somebody else, if you're going to copy how they play, at least get your own sound. Don't copy their tone also, you know, because if everyone sounds alike then it's just like making photocopies, everything looks and sounds alike. So that was one of the things that I always thought about and always tried to practice so that I wouldn't sound like anyone else. Of course now I always liked Ben Webster, and I always liked those, you know those beautiful sounds, but I would try and do it but I would try to do it with my own sound.

MW: In other words, it was okay to be influenced by somebody, and okay to try and do some of what they did conceptually, but not note for note.

RH: Yeah. Definitely. And another something too is now in order for me to learn how to drive a car, I have a take instructions from you and do what you do. But after I learn how to drive then I drive my own way. So that's what they always said. You know you might have to copy somebody in order to learn how to articulate or how to phrase well, you know, if you see somebody you like. But after that, after you learn that, then get your own thing so that people will say, this is so and so. And then you'll have your own identity.

MW: Do you think there are young students out today that emulate you?

RH: Ahhh, listen, you know what? I don't know. There was a friend of mine — in Los Angeles there's is a young fellow, he says, "He sounds like you." I said, "Well no, he doesn't have the sound." He said, "No, but the stuff that he plays and the phrasing," he said Ricky Woodard. I can't see it, but I listen to Ricky and there is this saxophone player, what's his name — Wilbur Brown. Now Wilbur Brown is a hell of a saxophone player. He lives in L.A. But he says, "Ricky Woodard sounds like you." I say, "Well not for tone," I say, "maybe he might have like some of the ideas." Now I'll tell you who sounds, we sound pretty close, Johnny Griffin and I. Because of the fact that one of the things about when I was young coming up, if I heard something on the radio and I copied it, I would call you up and say listen, meet me over so and so, and I'd show you this lick that I learned from maybe Don Byas or maybe whoever it was, Charlie Parker, and I would teach it to you. And when you learned something you'd call me up and tell me about it, and so we all did that, you know. I mean trumpet players, trombone players, it didn't really matter, you know? But today you can ask a young musician something, well you know he'd go off on some other stuff, and you never get an answer. So I don't know as though it's a closely guarded secret or something.

MW: I wanted to ask you about, you know there's different places in the country where ideas seem to gel collectively for musicians. And Milt Fillius asked us to ask you about Central Avenue, and the things that were going on and the people that you played with.

RH: Well, actually I never played on Central Avenue, but I was very aware of it. See like I say I was raised in Chicago. When I got to California, I got to California in the 60s, like in '67. But I had been to California in 1962 and '63 with Lloyd Price's band. But I never got on Central Avenue when it really was Central Avenue, you know, when it really had a lot of like Central Avenue Breakdown by Lionel Hampton, you know? In fact I was in New York before I got to California I went to New York in 1946 when I was in the service. I was in Aberdeen Proving Ground Maryland. And my first weekend I went to New York

you, I almost stopped playing. You heard music, and I mean this is when Bird and Diz and Errol Garner and everybody was on the street, and you heard real music. And I was still honking at that time. I was doing — I was playing Arnett Cobb and that type of saxophone. So and I heard all these changes and things I say, "I'll never be able to play like that." So I almost quit. But you know there's something, if you love music, you just say well I'm going to have to learn how to do this regardless, because I certainly don't want to be working in no foundry. Yeah, I remember when I got out of the service, I went to work in the Pullman Manufacturing Company. This was where they build the Vistadome, you know like when you take Amtrak, you can look out the observation car, you know, well I worked on the first one of those. And boy after about a month of that, I said, no I think I'm going to stick with this music. Yeah, so that really kind of put me on the straight and narrow.

MR: Can you tell us anything about your work with Joe Williams?

RH: Yeah, you know like I met Joe way back, in fact I wish I had thought about it. There is a clipping I could have brought from Club DeLisa in Chicago. And it was Joe Williams "Stop Pretty Baby, Stop," that song that he did. It's a little clipping from Club DeLisa. I was working with, what was her name, Little Miss Cornshucks, I was working at the Club DeLisa with her. And there was just a whole, just a whole advertisement of Joe Williams and with whom he was working, you know, Red Saunders and so, but like I met him way back years ago in Chicago, and he was gigging, like we all would work, we'd do our regular gig during the week, then on Monday morning they would have what you call a Breakfast Dance. Every club would have, like Club DeLisa, from it would go all night Sunday night and they would have a Breakfast Dance from, it would start at 6:00 and go until 8:00. Anybody that was playing anywhere in Chicago, I mean all musicians. This place held a thousand people. It was called Club DeLisa. Red Saunders has been there for about 30 years. And Joe Williams worked there for quite a few years. Billy Eckstine, a lot of your name entertainers worked at this club cause they had chorus girls, they had eight chorus girls, they had a nine piece band, and they had comedians, I mean these were real shows. You don't get real shows today. You get one singer after another. But like you had tap dancers, you had comedians, you had novelty acts, Butter Beans and Suzie, and Peg Leg Bates, you had a real collection of people to make up a show. The show would run maybe an hour and a half you know. But then when they would finish, when they would finish then the band would play for half an hour, and people would dance, you know the stage would go up for the show and when the show was over the stage would come down and people would go and dance. I mean it was a big affair, and the place would be jam packed every Monday morning. Then when you left the Club DeLisa, you

morning about 5 AM Tuesday morning. I mean and I mean every club had something happening. You know so what would happen, I used to see Joe, he might be working at DeLisa and then he would probably go over to maybe over on 39th Street or to the Dusable Hotel or some of those different places and maybe do a gig or something. And you'd always, everybody would meet up at a certain place and have breakfast, and during those days the popular food was brains and eggs. Of course I know you wouldn't think of that today. But you'd go have brains and eggs and biscuits and stuff like that and you'd hang out and talk stuff all morning. So Chicago really was, I mean like Dexter Gordon and Sonny Stitt and Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie — everybody would be in town. You would have the Dorsey Brothers and Harry James, but everyone would come to this particular club. So that's what I have, this club with Joe on it. And there were a few occasions where we would run across each other, because I'd work the Regal Theater which was the theater that had all the different shows, you know, and like Count Basie's band would come there and Duke Ellington, and they would still have a complete stage show with comedians and dancers and stuff. And Joe worked a lot of these different — So you know in your course of your playing this place to the other, you'd be playing with him, and I met him years ago. Yeah. He was light enough to ride a duck. But you know one of the things he always had a different type of voice than most vocalists. I mean his voice, his range was such, he had such a great range for his voice, that he could practically sing anything — opera as well as ballads. But of course now you know in America, the blues is always boss. I don't care, you know it was so funny when I used to work with Lloyd Price, the band would play, he had like a 14 piece band. Now James Brown had a seven piece band, Ray Charles had an 8 or 9 piece band, and I used to work with Lloyd Price and we would play at Small's Paradise in New York. So Lloyd Price would have James Brown as his guest, and then he'd have Ray Charles as his guest, but when both of them heard Lloyd's band, you know, like the band would start playing but we wouldn't be playing no blues to start off, we'd be playing some hip arrangements of whatever was popular for the day. And so when we were finished playing, and everybody had played their solos, and played like mad, the audience would say, "All right, now can y'all play us some blues?" So I'm just saying, blues is the boss. But when I mention a James Brown and Ray Charles, when they heard the band and heard what we played behind Lloyd Price, that's when they decided — this was way back in the '60s, they said, "I've got to have me a band, got to have me a band, can't have this seven piece." And Ray Charles sounded good with his little small group, but he sounded better with a big band. So they all decided to have a band. But no matter what you play, the blues is always the boss. I'm sorry to say but it's the truth. And I have this feeling for the blues

and all them, we used to work all, and what's his name, Collins, he's dead now, guitar player.

MR: Albert?

RH: Yeah, Albert Collins and Albert King, and all these blues players I used to work with years ago. Else McKinley, The Flamingos, and the El Dorados, and the Moonglows, all these people I've recorded with and worked with. So you get, you have a feeling for it.

MR: Did you find it different to work with British blues musicians?

RH: Well, one of the things about when you play with British musicians, they have a different concept for the blues. You know like our blues is kind of a blues about things that happen in our lives and stuff, and we base most of our material on something happy or something unhappy or stuff like that. But when they write songs, not all off them now, it could be about anything. It could be about their car or it could be about the bridge that they crossed last year. So it's just a little different feel. But I mean they basically get a good blues feeling some of them, but it's just a little different. It's not like what you're accustomed to hearing.

MW: Can you remember or recite us a blues lyric that you like?

RH: Oh, ho, you'd better turn that machine off.

MW: No, he told us to capture it, so go ahead, go ahead, go ahead.

RH: Well listen, when I used to work with Roosevelt Sykes, now they called him the original "honey dripper." And in fact I sing this song myself now but I have to be aware of where I can't sing this song here. But Roosevelt Sykes used to do this song, his theme song, he'd say: [sings] I want to do do — Why I want to do do — And people look around. And he say: I want to do do — What you want me to — I want to do do. But another song that he sang that I usually sing is like: [sings] My baby got an ice cream freezer — And she let me put my milk in her can — My baby's freezer ain't to be turned by no other man. Some folk like New York vanilla and strawberry, but black walnut is the cream I love. And when I put my spoon in that walnut, it fits just like a rubber glove.

MW: No, see, here's the thing I wanted to get at. Now when it comes time, somebody's singing that right?

RH: Yeah.

MW: And it comes times for the alto sax solo. And I'm trying to tell my students in my History of Jazz class about blue notes. So how you going to play something straight after that?

RH: That's right.

MW: If you can't bend tones after somebody singing that, you know, God put the horn back in the case.

RH: That's right, that's right, let me tell you. Oh Jimmy Witherspoon, I liked that line he got

right — You don't have to go to the dentist tomorrow baby — Cause I'm knocking out your teeth tonight. But you see one of the things, when we write blues, there's usually some kind of, it's almost like a poem in a sense. If it doesn't rhyme then the next phrase will rhyme and the next one after that, you know. And it always tells a story. Now there are a few exceptions to that rule, but they seem to still get over. John Lee Hooker's one. I mean he may say "Boom Boom Boom" but he's got that voice and he's got his type of rhythm that he can do that and get away with it.

MR: He sure can.

RH: And he can say anything and it goes because of his voice, and the way he pronounce. Another person that was like that — Jimmy Reed. Now Jimmy Reed was another, he was just a master of that. But all of his stuff kind of was lyrical and it had, it always came out. I remember, I'm trying to think where his wife was in the studio with him. And you could hear her saying the words and he would, I can remember —

MR: "Bright Lights, Big City?"

RH: Yeah, and "The Big Boss Man," I think, too. But she used to be, see I went on the road with Jimmy Reed in 1957, all down in Florida, and Jimmy Reed used to drink a lot of moonshine. During this period, people were dying of drinking moonshine. So we were trying to quit Jimmy Reed from drinking. So we got this newspaper. And Jimmy Reed, when he'd get to a city, he'd get him like a gallon of this white lightning. And I mean this stuff was so strong, it would, like if you'd drink it your lips would get chapped. So, and so we started, I'd read these things out loud. Yeah. Twelve people die in Okeechobee, Mississippi, drinking this moonshine and stuff. Then we'd turn the radio on and so like we'd see Jimmy throwing his moonshine out the window. So I'm just saying, you know, there are so many different type things that happen on the road that that's really, well that's how you get your lyrics for songs and stuff. And these things are about life and things that really happen in people's lives, you know.

MW: In other words, it's experiential.

RH: Exactly.

MW: That gives the music a certain sense of authenticity.

RH: Yeah, yeah. So like I feel very privileged to have lived during this particular era. Because a lot of the young musicians, they do no, well not all of them, but a lot of them don't do any research. Now I'll tell you, I had a chance to meet John Coltrane when he was with Dizzy. And I had met him before that, in fact I met him with Eddie "Cleanhead" Vinson. But he of course, he wasn't playing the way he was when he [inaudible]. But he could play the blues. I'm talking about play some real blues. And on one of his recent things, he and the alto player, oh.

RH: No, no, no, the one that they both worked with Cannonball, oh that was it, Cannonball. Now they played a blues, and let me tell you, they were playing the real funk, stunk down, knock me down blues, you know. And that's what you don't hear too much. See so although they did play other things, they were able to play that because of the fact that they had this blues background. And that's what's very important. And when you don't get a chance to experience playing the blues, you really just, you really don't have any foundation for what you play. You know you have to have that kind of a background. And I'm sure that any musician that even anyone that, your most modern blues players, I mean jazz players, will tell you that. Some of them don't particularly feature that in their playing. But they have that blues background that they can do it if they want to, you know. And that's what's really important.

MW: And there seems to be a difference there, I'd like you to speak on this. The difference between execution and expression.

RH: Well there were a few people who could execute and express themselves beautifully and make it sound very melodic and convincing and with feeling. Then you've got some who play four million notes and you don't feel nothing and you haven't heard anything, you know. Now Bird was one who could play, I mean, fast and he could play a whole lot of stuff, and Sonny Stitt, Diz, and I mean with feeling, like when Bird played with Jay McShann. Man that cat when he got through playing some of them solos he played a million notes but they were important, they were not wasted, they were not just some notes. I mean it wasn't a whole song, but it was just between certain phrases. He'd play maybe some cadenzas there inside those different phrases, and you'd say God damn, how did he do that? And then he'd lean on some of those blue notes, and boy I mean like it's just something when you hear it, you know you can't forget it. In fact, if you are a musician, if you hear it at night you go home and want to practice. Of course now Coltrane could do that too, because he had a very wonderful background with blues and stuff. And of course after a while you start teaching yourself, when you get the basics then you can venture out on your own and do whatever you want to do, you know. And I must say most of your stuff that he did, it made sense, it made sense, it made great sense. A lot of people don't think so. There are some things during the experimental time that didn't make too much sense, but after he really got into the groove of what was happening and finally got his — and what was that thing he said? He said sometimes he have so many ideas at one time he'd just play them all. He say he just play them all. So but that's great, cause sometimes some people can't do that. Some people can only play a certain select few ideas and I think the real goal of any musician is to be able to play all of their ideas, not necessarily all together, nevertheless, I think they should be able to

express themselves musically. So it's possible to play a lot of different things and still play it with feeling.

MR: Did you say you were going to Australia soon?

RH: Yeah, I'm going the 19th of April.

MR: That's nice.

RH: Yeah, well my first trip to Australia was in 1973 with John Mayall. And in fact Blue Mitchell and Freddy Robinson, I don't know if you're familiar with these names—

MR: I remember, did you make a record with him that had no drummer on it or something? I remember hearing a record of his, but I remember your name on it.

RH: Uh, I don't remember making one with no drummer, but we did do some peculiar things. I remember many times when I first joined him, I said, "Well when we gonna rehearse?" "Oh I don't have rehearsals." I said, "What? You don't have no rehearsals?" I said, "What am I going to play?" "Oh you'll find something." I asked Blue Mitchell, I say, "Man, what am I gonna play?" "Oh don't worry about it, you'll find something." He says the reason he doesn't rehearse is because he likes for it to be spontaneous. Your ideas, he say, he don't want you to rehearse your ideas to put on the song. He wants you to be able to when you hear it play it. That's the way he likes it. I said, "Fine with me." So I just played whatever I felt I wanted to play. "Perfect, perfect!" I said, "That wasn't shit." But you know like I noticed that the audience, they went wild. I said, "I can't believe this, man. What is this?" But it worked, so I said who am I to tell another person how to make his omelet? So, but I must say I enjoyed working with him. I made more money with John Mayall than any big band I ever worked with. And like when we would finish a 15-week tour, in Europe or wherever, he'd say, "Well fellas," like if we were in Europe, he'd say, "Well I'm going to Spain for two weeks, anybody want to go? Come on, everything is free. You want your ladies sent for, I'll pay for it." And he'd maybe give you a couple of grand or a bonus at the end of the tour, stuff like that. I mean of course John Mayall was a millionaire, and he was making 50 or 60 thousand a night. So he could afford to do that, you know? And he like he couldn't tell you a note big as this room, but he know chords and he could write out the chords to his song but they would be just basic chords, wouldn't be no flat this and raise that.

MR: Just basic chords?

RH: It could be C minor, or C7 or whatever, it wouldn't be no diminished this. But it was really, it was really nice. In fact there was one other period I made a record with and we went in and to show you how things can be done, now this was we were in the studio with Bill Cosby. And I made an LP with him. We made an LP in about 4 hours and 20 minutes. And we had no idea what he was going to play, and what he was gonna— there

player what to play. He say, "Now Red, you play" [scats]. Then he would have the drummer to fill up the rhythm and the other horns and the guitar, he'd give you all your parts, and then we'd play that for maybe a couple of choruses, then he'd change it around, so it would take us maybe, it would take us maybe of 20 minutes to get a song together, then we'd record it. We'd play it twice. Three times at the most. And that was it. But I mean he had all this in his head. He knew what he wanted to do, he didn't have the music because he didn't know nothing about writing any music, but Bill Cosby played a little drums, so he knew the rhythms and things, and he could sing. And we recorded a whole album, Yeah.

MR: I wonder if we could finish up with some suggestions to our viewers of what your, if we were going to listen to some Red Holloway, what are some of your favorite recordings you've had?

RH: I think my most famous record is I did an LP, the title of it was "No Tears Over You" and all of these songs I wrote myself except for one which was Art Hillary, he wrote one song on it. And the song "No Tears" and then there was another one called "Hittin' the Road Again." Now I went in the studio and we rehearsed and played it on the job. Then we went in the studio and we cut it in about 3-1/2 hours, this album, cause I was paying, you see, myself. So we ain't going to be wasting no time here fellas. If you got anything on your mind, speak now. I think that was my best album. Because then there was a song titled "Music for Making Love." I wrote this song for a pornography film, but then I took the music for my own album because I liked it so much. But I think, now there was one Clark Terry and I did called "Locksmith Blues." My baby told me my key won't fit her lock no more. But I'm a master locksmith, momma, I got a key that will fit any door. You know. Now that was one I wrote, and Clark really surprised me on that because he, the broad's name was "Hey Magnolia" and Clark was supposed to say something, but he answered in a woman's voice, he say, "What." I say, "Huh?" Because I didn't know he was going to do that, you know. And I think that was my best album because I did something I wanted to do, and between "Locksmith Blues" and "No Tears Over You," I think those are my two best.

MW: You know I wanted to make just one comment about some of the things that you've said and what you've been telling us about the blues lyrics is that I sense in your music this marvelous sense of humor. Do you think we could have more of that in music today? I think music needs some of that to come back.

RH: I think it would be nice to have some kind of sense of humor in your music as well as seriousness when it comes to like playing say like "My Funny Valentine" or something like that. You can really make a person feel like this is my valentine. Or if you play like

was something very unique and very few people are able to capture that type of feelings anymore. She just had that certain voice. And if you notice, there are certain people that come along, maybe every two decades, and they will have like, well, like Sarah Vaughan, like Billie Holiday, Nat King Cole. They have that certain something in their voices, you know, Ella Fitzgerald, there's just something — that's another person that's alive now, that's still alive, Gloria Lynne, she's another that has that certain — you don't hear much about her. But they have, you know like people can be talking and if you got certain something, they'll stop talking and listen. Gene Ammons had that, he could do that you know. So there's just a, I don't know what it is that's in the plan but it works out that every — well like when Coleman Hawkins came along, when Lester Young came along, Charlie Parker, John Coltrane. Now I don't know no one else that's surfaced yet that's really an innovator like these people so far. They're all followers and clones, but nobody at the moment is really doing nothing different. They all follow this pattern. I think that's the highest form of flattery, you know, when somebody want to do something like you do. But I'm just wondering, because all of the great people are dying. Billy Eckstine, all the really great voices, you know.

MW: That's one reason that we're doing these interviews. And we consider you one of those people that we wanted on tape very much, so we want you to receive that as an honor, and we wanted to get your words and your thoughts.

RH: That's a real beautiful compliment. I do thank you very much. But it's just something that Clark Terry, I talked to him on — now one of our friends in Chicago, Lonnie Simmons, an organ player, used to work at this club I was telling you about Club DeLisa, he worked there for I don't know, at least 30 years. He just died in February. So just so many people are dying, friends that we know who really had something to say, and like I think about Clark all the time because he's one of the last of the real heavyweights.

MW: Clark Terry is being brought to our college in May to receive an honorary doctorate.

RH: Oh, that's great. That's great. Let me tell you. I've worked, well I worked in Chicago New Years with Clark, and I've been working with him on and off for you know like whenever we can get a gig together. And this man is really a giver. He's not a taker. He's got this jazz institute in Iowa, the Clark Terry Jazz Institute, it's a techy old university, in LeMars, Iowa, and I've taught a few classes there. In fact I'm supposed to go there in June. But I like, I do whatever I can for him. You know I'll refuse a gig to work with him, because of the fact that he's a giver. And being an only child, and you know I've always been a giver. My mother taught me like, don't always have your hands out. Reach in your pocket and give somebody something if you got something. So that's the way I feel I guess, that's why I'm poor today, cause I give it all away. But you know, I ain't

MR: That's great. We want to thank Red Holloway for sharing all these great thoughts with us, and, you said some things today that I think ought to be written down and recited to some of our — some great, great quotes.

RH: Well thank you very much. But these are, as I see them. And thank you for having me, and I do thank you very, very, very much, and I do hope to see you all again sometime soon, just in your own colleges or universities, just as a visitor or whatever.

MR: We'll be listening tomorrow morning to you too.

RH: Oh my goodness, I'd better get a good night's sleep tonight.

MW: Well most of our interviews will be over and we're just going to come tomorrow just to listen.

RH: Oh, okay then, that's beautiful. And I want to thank you very much.

MR: Thank you.

MW: Thank you.